

In my day, I've met many successful men and women, too many of whom express their pride in having done it all themselves. But I don't believe that any one of us can take sole credit for our success. Most of us have been blessed by the nurture and love of our families, the support of our friends and colleagues, the dedication of our teachers, and the inspiration and guidance of our mentors, to say nothing of the providence that brought us the opportunity to realize our goals. "We did it *ourselves*." Really? When I hear that, I'm bold enough to ask, "Now just how did you arrange to be born in the United States of America?"

And so I come to my final affirmation of commitment: commitment to our nation—"America the Beautiful," in the words of the hymn. Please neither derogate our heritage as Americans nor take it for granted. And, for that matter, never think that we have arrived at perfection, as this splendid verse of the hymn—my favorite—warns: "America! America! God mend thine every flaw. Confirm thy soul in self-control, thy liberty in law." The moment we boldly commit ourselves to doing all we can, every day, to measure up to the elementary principles of good citizenship, magic follows for our nation, too.

So, it's up to each of us to summon our unique genius, our own power, and our personal magic. Just as it has done so unfailingly for me, providence will respond for you. It really will! So in everything you do, be bold. Each of us must decide for ourselves how much to focus on things, and indeed what things to focus on. But I know that each one of us can profit by some moments of quiet introspection about whether our lives are driven far too much by the accumulation of things, and not nearly enough by the exercise of bold commitment to our family, to our work, to a worthy cause, to our society, and to our world.